

This is a quick, practical cheat sheet of essential Fastboot commands with examples for flashing, unlocking bootloader, slot switching, and device recovery.

[illegible]

Fastboot Commands List for Android

If you work on Android phones regularly, you have probably used Fastboot at least once. It is one of the most reliable command-line tools for flashing partitions, unlocking bootloaders, entering different modes, and recovering devices that refuse to boot normally. The Fastboot tool is included in the [Android SDK Platform Tools package](#), the same package that contains ADB.

In this guide, we are sharing a complete Fastboot commands list for Android with a short explanation and practical example for each command. You can bookmark this page as a quick Fastboot cheat sheet and come back whenever you need a command reference / examples when working this tool and your Android device.

`fastboot` communicates with Android devices when they are in bootloader / Fastboot mode. Unlike [ADB](#) (which works when Android is running), Fastboot is mostly used for low-level operations like flashing images, unlocking, slot switching, and boot-time diagnostics. It is a client-server program that includes three components:

- **Client:** The `fastboot` command you run on your computer.
- **Device bootloader:** Receives and executes Fastboot commands.

- **USB / transport layer:** Carries command packets between your computer and phone.

Fastboot is a Unix shell, which means it is fully compatible with Windows, macOS and Linux systems.

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All Fastboot Commands List

Directory

Fastboot is part of the Android SDK Platform-Tools package.

There are a small number of base Fastboot commands, but with different arguments and partition targets, you can do a lot. Before running any command, [install device USB drivers](#), use the latest Platform Tools, and confirm your phone is in Fastboot mode.

Open a terminal or command prompt in your `platform-tools` folder, then run commands from the list below.

fastboot devices

The `fastboot devices` command shows all connected devices detected in Fastboot mode.

Example:

```
fastboot devices
```

fastboot reboot

Use `fastboot reboot` to reboot the phone back to Android system.

Example:

```
fastboot reboot
```

fastboot reboot bootloader

This command reboots the device back into the bootloader/Fastboot screen.

Example:

```
fastboot reboot bootloader
```

fastboot reboot recovery

Use this command to reboot directly to recovery (supported on many devices).

Example:

```
fastboot reboot recovery
```

fastboot getvar all

`fastboot getvar all` prints available bootloader variables such as product, bootloader version, and security flags.

Example:

```
fastboot getvar all
```

fastboot getvar product

Use this to quickly verify the target product codename.

Example:

```
fastboot getvar product
```

fastboot getvar current-slot

On A/B partition devices, this shows the currently active slot.

Example:

```
fastboot getvar current-slot
```

fastboot getvar unlocked

This command helps verify whether the bootloader is unlocked.

Example:

```
fastboot getvar unlocked
```

fastboot flashing unlock

On modern devices, this is the standard command to unlock the bootloader.

Example:

```
fastboot flashing unlock
```

fastboot flashing unlock_critical

Some devices separate critical partitions. Use this command only if your device documentation explicitly requires it.

Example:

```
fastboot flashing unlock_critical
```

fastboot flashing lock

Use this command to relock the bootloader after returning to complete stock firmware.

Example:

```
fastboot flashing lock
```

fastboot flashing lock_critical

Relocks critical partitions on devices that support critical unlock/lock states.

Example:

```
fastboot flashing lock_critical
```

fastboot oem unlock (legacy)

Older OEM bootloaders used `fastboot oem unlock` instead of `fastboot flashing unlock` .

Example:

```
fastboot oem unlock
```

Note: This is a legacy command and may not work on modern devices.

fastboot oem lock (legacy)

Legacy command used on older devices to relock bootloader.

Example:

```
fastboot oem lock
```

fastboot flash boot boot.img

Flashes a `boot.img` file to the boot partition.

Example:

```
fastboot flash boot boot.img
```

fastboot flash recovery recovery.img

Flashes a recovery image to the recovery partition (older devices and some custom setups).

Example:

```
fastboot flash recovery recovery.img
```

fastboot flash system system.img

Writes the system image file to the system partition.

Example:

```
fastboot flash system system.img
```

fastboot flash vendor vendor.img

Flashes vendor partition image.

Example:

```
fastboot flash vendor vendor.img
```

fastboot flash vbmeta vbmeta.img

Flashes `vbmeta` metadata required for Android Verified Boot chains.

Example:

```
fastboot flash vbmeta vbmeta.img
```

fastboot --disable-verity --disable-verification flash vbmeta vbmeta.img

Commonly used in custom flashing workflows to disable dm-verity and AVB verification.

Example:

```
fastboot --disable-verity --disable-verification flash vbmeta vbmeta.img
```

fastboot boot recovery.img

Boots an image temporarily without permanently flashing it.

Example:

```
fastboot boot recovery.img
```

fastboot erase userdata

Erases the userdata partition.

Example:

```
fastboot erase userdata
```

fastboot erase cache

Erases cache partition on devices where it exists.

Example:

```
fastboot erase cache
```

fastboot -w

Performs a data wipe (typically userdata + cache where applicable).

Example:

```
fastboot -w
```

fastboot format userdata

Formats the userdata partition using the filesystem expected by the device.

Example:

```
fastboot format userdata
```

fastboot format cache

Formats cache partition (legacy/partition-layout dependent).

Example:

```
fastboot format cache
```

fastboot set_active a

On A/B devices, this sets slot `a` as active.

Example:

```
fastboot set_active a
```

fastboot set_active b

On A/B devices, this sets slot `b` as active.

Example:

```
fastboot set_active b
```


fastboot --set-active=a

Alternative syntax used in some scripts to switch active slot.

Example:

```
fastboot --set-active=a
```

fastboot --set-active=b

Alternative syntax for setting slot `b` active.

Example:

```
fastboot --set-active=b
```

fastboot flash boot_a boot.img

Flashes boot image directly to slot A.

Example:

```
fastboot flash boot_a boot.img
```

fastboot flash boot_b boot.img

Flashes boot image directly to slot B.

Example:

```
fastboot flash boot_b boot.img
```

fastboot flash system_a system.img

Flashes system image to slot A.

Example:

```
fastboot flash system_a system.img
```

fastboot flash system_b system.img

Flashes system image to slot B.

Example:

```
fastboot flash system_b system.img
```

fastboot flashall

Flashes all partitions from a factory image script context.

Example:

```
fastboot flashall
```

fastboot update image.zip

Flashes a complete update package ZIP that contains Android images and metadata.

Example:

```
fastboot update image.zip
```

fastboot continue

Leaves Fastboot mode and continues normal boot sequence.

Example:

```
fastboot continue
```

fastboot snapshot-update cancel

Used on supported devices to cancel a pending snapshot update.

Example:

fastboot snapshot-update cancel

fastboot fetch vendor_boot vendor_boot.img (advanced)

On newer Fastboot implementations, `fetch` can retrieve a partition image from device.

Example:

```
fastboot fetch vendor_boot vendor_boot.img
```

Note: Availability depends on device bootloader and Fastboot implementation.

fastboot flashing get_unlock_ability

Checks whether the device allows bootloader unlock.

Example:

```
fastboot flashing get_unlock_ability
```

fastboot help

Displays available commands for your installed Fastboot binary.

Example:

```
fastboot help
```

Fastboot is one of those tools that can save hours when you are recovering a soft-bricked device or doing manual firmware work. At the same time, it is also easy to misuse. Always verify your partition target and image file before pressing Enter, and keep a full stock firmware package ready for recovery.

If you have been a long-time Team Android reader, you must have seen how often we use Fastboot to install custom ROMs and custom recovery images.

And if you think we should add more commands to this cheat sheet, drop them in the comments and we will keep this guide updated. You should also check out the official [Android Fastboot documentation page](#) on flashing images.

FAQs

What is Fastboot used for on Android?

Fastboot is used for low-level bootloader operations such as unlocking/relocking the bootloader, flashing partition images, switching A/B slots, and recovering devices that cannot boot into Android.

What is the difference between ADB and Fastboot?

ADB works when Android OS (or recovery with ADB support) is running. Fastboot works at bootloader level before Android starts, so it is used for firmware and partition-level changes.

Why is my phone not showing in `fastboot devices` ?

Usually this is due to missing USB drivers, a bad cable/port, or not being in true Fastboot/bootloader mode. Reinstall drivers, switch USB ports, and run `fastboot devices` again.

Is `fastboot oem unlock` still valid?

On many older devices yes, but modern devices generally use `fastboot flashing unlock` . Always follow the method required

by your phone's manufacturer. It is different for older/newer Google Pixel devices.

Is it safe to use `fastboot flash` commands?

It is safe only when you are flashing the correct file to the correct partition for your exact model. You need to double-check or triple-check before flashing. A wrong image or partition target can cause bootloops or hard-to-recover states.

What does `fastboot -w` do?

`fastboot -w` wipes user data (and cache on supported layouts). You should back up everything first because data removal is irreversible.

Can I switch slots on A/B devices with Fastboot?

Yes. Use `fastboot set_active a` or `fastboot set_active b` , then reboot.

You can confirm active slot with `fastboot getvar current-slot` .

Tags

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Salman Arif

Salman is a full-time Android developer where he crafts amazing experiences for mobile devices. He also likes to write and contribute to blogs where he discusses the development side of Android and help developers maximize their productivity with various developer tools.

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